



IN THE NET: Officials educating fishermen about the importance of turtle conservation (top left); turtles harpooned by poachers (above)

tion has become a key concern for environmentalists. In fact, ecologists say that with the turtle population in West Bengal becoming thinner, illegal traders are sourcing these animals from states as distant as Punjab and Gujarat.

Jayesh Bhatt, director (Gujarat) of wwf India, says all these turtles are invariably bound for West Bengal. Their allegedly high food value apart, the reptiles are randomly poached for their shells which are smuggled out of the country for medicinal purposes. "The shells are believed to be rich in calcium," says Mohanty. Moreover, smaller varieties like the star tortoise are popular as pets and fetch anything close to \$100 (Rs 4,093) each abroad.

SHELL SHOCK

- According to a study, as many as five out of the 11 species of freshwater turtles typically found in Orissa, no longer exist.
- Apart from their supposedly high food value, turtles are poached for their shells that are believed to be rich in calcium and smuggled out of the country for medicinal use.
- Smaller varieties like the star tortoise are popular as pets and can fetch anything close to \$100.
- With a decline in the turtle population in West Bengal, illegal traders are now sourcing them from Punjab and Gujarat.

Poachers use various methods to trap turtles and most are crude enough to harm and kill the animal during the process itself. Often, a line of multiple sharp fishing hooks are strung along a fishing line and placed across the river. The animals get entangled in these hooks and are then easy to catch. Or they are caught using rotten flesh as bait. For this, a piece of flesh is put on a fishing hook and a turtle trying to eat it gets caught. Sometimes, a carcass of a cow, dog or buffalo is kept near the river bank as a bait and the poachers catch the reptile as it comes out to feed on the body.

Pointing out that the initiative taken by the West Bengal government is not enough to keep a thorough check on the trade, Mohanty regrets that few arrests are made when consignments are seized in the state. "We have found even Bangladeshi fishermen coming and camping in various places in Orissa. They pay local fishermen a small amount of money, and in return are allowed to poach the turtles," he adds.

Much of the problem is believed to have resulted from lack of appropriate awareness among the locals. When the wso team went about educating fishermen in the rural areas about the importance of conservation of turtles, it found the response more than encouraging.

In fact, some locals have stopped entertaining Bangladeshi fishermen in Orissa. The awareness programme has received a further impetus with help coming from a Kolkata-based apparel firm which has tied up with wso and wwf for the conservation of freshwater turtles in Orissa and Gujarat. After work began at the Mahanadi river, the upstream areas (Cuttack and upwards) are now believed to be relatively safer for the animal although it is alleged that nearly 2-3 quintal of the *Lisseyms Punctata*—the most abundant variety—are still smuggled out every week.

Apart from deliberate poaching, turtles are often inadvertently caught by fishermen whose trawlers are not fitted with turtle excluders. Fishermen in the Mahanadi have now begun complaining about how the turtles are damaging their nets and ironically want the government to compensate them. It is time the turtles were compensated for all the losses they had to suffer all these years. ■